Kashmir has been a part of my life since I was a child of twelve. My father was posted as the commanding officer of the Recovery Company at Jammu and Udhampur military stations for four years, from 1957–60. Our house was located in Satwari square, a suburb of Jammu, where the officers of the J&K state forces used to stay. Some houses were given to the army and we were lucky enough to get one of them. There were about forty houses in a hollow square configuration in that locality, flanked by the Ranbir canal. Named after Maharaja Ranbir Singh, the ruler of J&K from 1857–85, the canal carries ice-cold water from the Chenab river and originates from the barrage at Akhnur. In those days, this canal was used by us to refrigerate fruit, soft drinks and even beer bottles, and people sat on its bank and dipped their feet and literally cooled their heels. It was a challenge to swim in its freezing waters, but our spirit of adventure and taking 'pangas' (uncalled for hazardous or risky ventures) made us not only dive into the canal, but also swim through the aquaducts under the bridges. In those freezing waters we couldn't stay submerged for more than a minute or two. But it was great fun. The canal was also a popular place for a walk or a drive, as one got to see the beautiful Dogri damsels bathing in it! Since the road ran parallel to the canal and in close proximity to it, we learnt that many army trucks ended up driving into the canal or had accidents, because of this distraction.

Once, while celebrating the lohri festival that signifies the end of the winter season in north India, we augmented our collection of firewood by stealing all the wooden name boards from the gates of houses in our colony, so that we could enjoy the bonfire for a longer time. Our mischief was discovered within a day or two. We received a proper dressing down by our parents, but finally, it was laughed off as no house had been spared.

I have vivid memories of two visits to the Kashmir valley as a teenager, during 1957–60. The first one was by three of us siblings, all by ourselves. A huge recovery vehicle was being repositioned from Jammu to Srinagar, and we hitched a ride. It turned out to be an amazing journey, and maybe a record of sorts! The driver's cabin was spacious, and the three of us made ourselves fairly comfortable